Mohandas Gandhi (1869–1948) raised when he returned from South Africa in 1915 and embarked on a two-year discovery of India, often travelling in third-class railway carriages.[84] When political protests gathered steam, passengers slowly began asserting their rights. ‘To stop train, pull chain’, a common sign and rarely used service in trains even today, was popularized in the early 20th century as a way to alert authorities about the problem of overcrowding.[85]

Over the past century, the comforts of railway travel have improved but the high density of railway trains continues to haunt the migrant worker. As a commuter in Mumbai, I would watch passengers travel in the wrong direction for ten minutes in order to grab a seat for their hour-long journey. Similarly, in Odisha’s Ganjam, I have seen migrant workers travel two hours in the wrong direction to Puri in order to get a seat for the fifty-three-hour journey of the Puri–Okha Express, that too after dutifully seeking blessings at Jagannath Temple. The third-class carriage is now called the ‘general compartment’ and moves with deafening silence, carrying the dreams of countless migrant workers.

The railways did not only move migrants from home to work. They were also the source of migrant work. Between 1853 and 1900, an estimated 8 million workers in south Asia were put to work to construct the railways.[86] The construction of the line in Bhor Ghat in the 1850s, which opened up Bombay to the Deccan, required over 3000 rock-cutting migrant workers, 6000 bullocks and 1000 carts to work in the hills on any given day, and 42,000 workers in all to complete the project.[87] Millions of circulatory migrant workers have since then contributed towards building the railway network from scratch to over 90,000 km today.[88] The railways itself grew to be one of the largest employers of the world with over one million people, many of them migrants or made to move due to official transfers.

The railways, it is often argued, facilitated mobility that for the first time brought about a sense of unity in the subcontinent. Gandhi, a bitter critic of the railways, opposed this view but even he had to concede that it had brought Indians ‘assembled under one roof’.[89] Bhimrao Ambedkar argued that caste practices were momentarily paused only during rail journeys and